

The Game's On

With 1,700 gaming titles across all platforms, 23-year-old Manan Bhanushali is a first among equals. This is a glimpse of the man who has spent Rs 3 lakh on buying original games



Manan's Picks

GameCube

Metroid (Rs 3,000)
Super Mario Sunshine
(Rs 2,500)

Game Boy Advance

*Spiderman Mysterious
Menace* (Rs 1,900)
Golden Sun (Rs 1,200)

Play Station 2

Final Fantasy X
(Rs 2,999)

XBox

Ninja Garden (Rs 3,000)
Halo (Rs 3,500)

PC games

Black and White
(Rs 1,999)
Metal Gear Solid
(Rs 1,500)
*Unreal tournament
2004 - Special DVD
edition* (Rs 2,000)
*Baldur's Gate, complete
pack* (Rs 4,000)

Meera Vankipuram

As you enter Manan Bhanushali's modest apartment in Garodia Nagar, located in north-central Mumbai, everything seems pretty ordinary—from the twin-apartment with teak furniture, to the old world look of the interiors and the conservative Marwari family talking in hushed tones. Step inside Manan's room, however, and the illusion fades away.

Placed neatly on shelves on a sidewall are a Sony PlayStation 2, a Microsoft Xbox and the Nintendo Game Cube—the three most powerful consoles that any gamer worth his salt would die for. If that's not enough, Manan introduces you to two more gadgets—the Game Boy Advance SP, and a Nokia N-Gage QD, a newer, slicker version of the N-Gage. "The QD lets you play arcade and console games, and also online multiplayer games using Bluetooth," he says.

But these are just the starters. He opens a cupboard, and steps away so you can peep into his gargantuan collection—1,700 game titles costing around Rs 3 lakh, including Xbox, PS2, Game Cube and N-Gage games. Most purchased from abroad, courtesy obliging friends and relatives.

He is also a familiar face amongst game dealers in Mumbai. "Unfortunately, they charge me way more than the actual store price," he says.

His collection covers all the game genres there are, "except flight simulators!" Gamers will drool at adventure titles such as *Broken Sword*, role playing games (RPGs) such as the *Final Fantasy* series, strategy games such as the *Hero* series, action games such as *Quake III*, *Unreal Tournament 2004*, *Doom 3*, *Max Payne* and *BloodRayne*.

"Piracy is inevitable, especially in India. If official versions are not released simultaneously in India, pirated copies hit the grey market in a day or two. Gamers do not like to wait," he says with a wry smile. "International companies are realising the need to enter and cater to the Indian market. The Nokia N-Gage for example, has a decent price-point (street price: Rs 9,000) for the Indian market," he adds.

"I want to pursue a career in gaming. I think I was born to play games."

Manan is 23, and has a Diploma in Computer Technology. In his final year, he was offered a job with Milestone Interactive Software, India's leading distributor and developer of PC and console games, as a technical support executive. He soon became a product specialist, which let him write game reviews, maintain their Web site and test games. Manan's plans include developing games for mobile phones. "I'm reading up on J2ME now. I want to pursue a career in gaming; I think I was born to play games! I intend to start a company of my own, to develop and market games," he says.

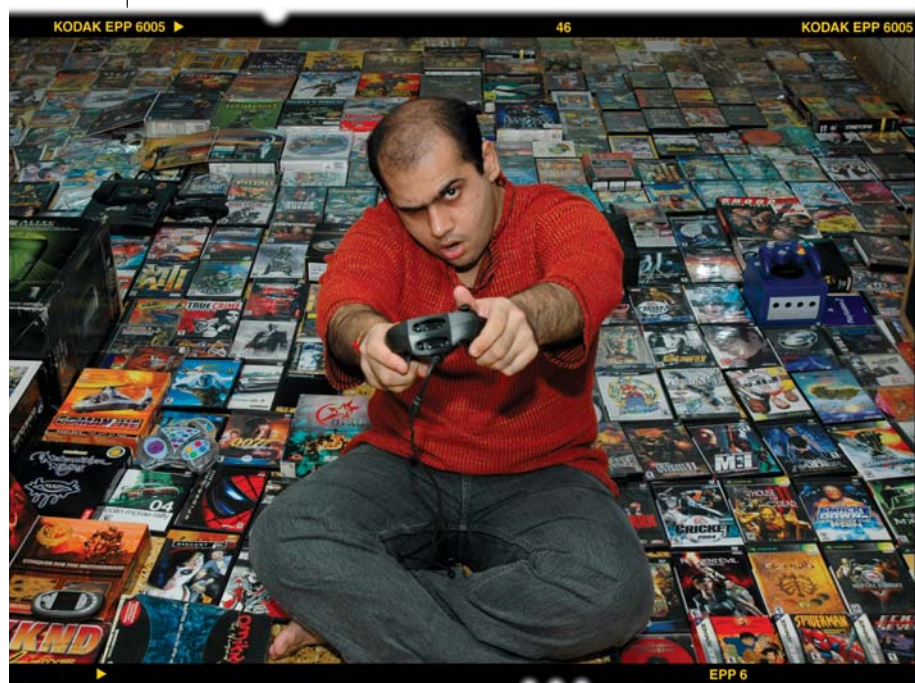
Manan started gaming at the age of four—from *Space Invaders* on an Atari, to EXE files that masqueraded as games on his old 386 such as id Software's *Wolfenstein 3D*. Manan today owns an AMD Athlon 2000+ XP, with 512 MB DDR RAM, a 40 GB 7,200 rpm hard disk and an ASUS GeForce FX 5600 Ultra graphics card.

He has also travelled to Chennai, Bangalore, Kolkata, and Delhi to provide tech support to the gaming community. He even trained the staff at McDonald's to use the PS2.

As Manan begins a session of *Resident Evil*, the room quakes with the powerful sound effects and the near-real graphics. "Pay attention to the details," he says, as he points to the way the leaves of a plant sway with the wind, on screen. "I'd give *Resident Evil* and *Metroid Prime* 10-on-10 for detailed graphics."

Given a choice, Manan would prefer to 'Enter the Matrix'. Reality can wait a while! ☒

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Gameboy: Manan Bhanushali can go on, and on, and on...